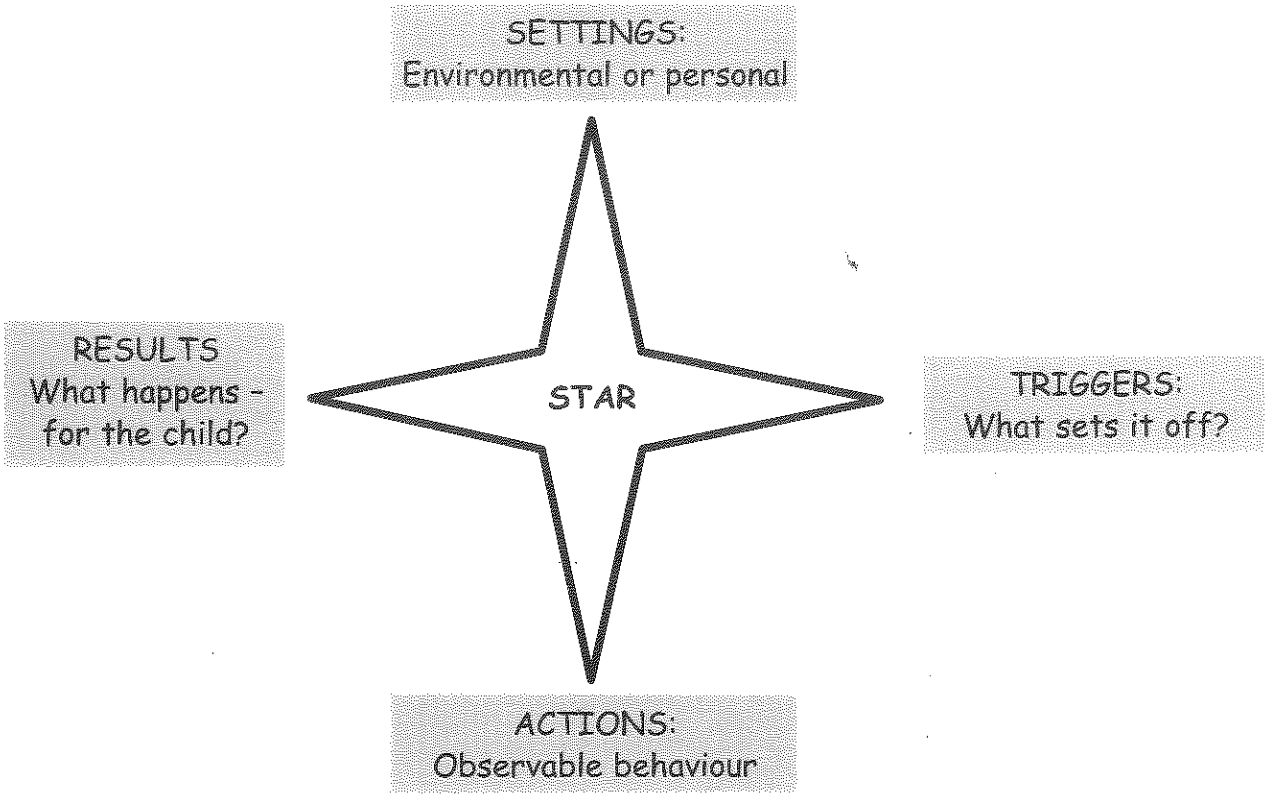
# 5B: Analyse to manage behaviour

To 'Be detectives', the iceberg is a good way to consider factors that might underlie behaviours observed in the child. To extend this analysis – and work out how to manage the behaviour – another useful approach is 'STAR' (Zarkowska and Clements, 1994).

'STAR' stands for:
- Settings
- Triggers
- Actions
- Results

The STAR approach recommends that problem behaviours should be regarded as purposeful actions, usually aimed at achieving specific results, and therefore serving a function for the person with an ASD. The function may well be an attempt to communicate: perhaps to gain attention, to refuse to do something, to express a need, or to express feelings. Often the best aim is to teach and encourage an appropriate behaviour to serve the same function (eg giving a picture symbol to ask for a toy, instead of throwing a tantrum.)



1. Just as with the iceberg, a STAR analysis begins by considering the ACTION which is of concern, so the behaviour to be analysed is identified and described (objectively). Then the likely FUNCTION of this action is described.

2. Next, a STAR analysis looks at the SETTINGS: which may be environmental or personal.

Environmental setting conditions include:
a) Physical aspects of the child's environment (eg temperature, space)
b) The social interactions and relationships within that environment
c) The activities which the child is doing

Personal setting conditions include:
a) The child's physical well-being
b) The child's psychological state
c) The child's thoughts and moods

3. Next, a STAR analysis looks at possible TRIGGERS: the signals or stimuli present in a situation that might 'set off' certain behaviours. Triggers usually occur shortly before the behaviour of concern. Possible triggers include:

a) The availability of something the child wants.
b) The approach of something the child dislikes or fears.
c) The occurrence of something the child associates with a particular event.

4. Next, a STAR analysis looks at RESULTS: the events that follow the action – in particular, the consequences of the action for the child. The results will influence the likelihood of a behaviour recurring: if the results are pleasant for the child, they will 'reward' the behaviour and will be likely to recur. Types of results include:

a) Positive results: the action results in pleasant consequences for the child, so the behaviour is likely to recur.
b) Negative results: such as the withholding of attention or of a desired reward – so that the behaviour is less likely to recur.
c) Social results: eg the child gains attention or comfort – or succeeds in avoiding unwanted social contact.
d) Sensory results: the child gains sensory pleasure – or avoids sensory overload.
e) Material results: the child gains food, drink, or a desired object.
f) Occupational results: the child gets to do a desired activity – or to escape an unwanted activity.

## Using the STAR approach to manage a behaviour

- Describe the ACTION:

eg " Fred slaps my face."

- Decide on the likely function of this action:

eg "Fred slaps me to refuse to do what I ask him to do."

- Look at the SETTING, possible TRIGGERS, and RESULTS:

eg "Fred slaps me when I tell him it's time for a bath.
He is frightened of the fan in the bathroom.
When he slaps me I get upset and let him play instead of going upstairs."

- To manage this behaviour, you might consider:

a) Altering the result: perhaps not letting Fred be 'rewarded' for slapping by delaying his feared visit to the bathroom.

b) Manipulating a trigger: perhaps playing a favourite tape in the bathroom to drown out the feared fan noise (or disconnecting the fan!)

c) Teaching an alternative action: perhaps giving Fred a favourite bath toy and his sponge to hold when you tell him it is bath time, so he is less likely to slap you.

- Make any changes gradually.

- Use prompts, if appropriate, to teach an alternative behaviour.

- Reward any appropriate new behaviour immediately.

Reference for STAR: Zarkowska, E. and Clements, J. (1994): Problem Behaviour and People with Severe Learning Disabilities: the S.T.A.R. approach. London: Chapman and Hall.

## Practice in using STAR

Story: Sam and his family are in a café. There are lots of people and it is noisy. Dad goes to get the drinks and a snack. Sam can see children with pop and crisps on the next table. Dad brings drinks and cakes. Sam throws his cake on the floor. Dad shouts at him. Mum gets him a packet of crisps.

What happened? Where? When? Who with? Why? Who was it a problem for?

Now try a STAR analysis:

1. Describe the ACTION: What happened?

2. Describe any SETTING factors: Where? Who with? When?

3. Describe any possible TRIGGERS: Who? What? When?

4. Describe the RESULTS: for Sam?

Who was it a problem for?

## Managing Sam's behaviour:

What might Sam's parents do differently, in future, to manage Sam's behaviour in this situation? Write here your ideas for what they might change:

Could they change the SETTING? How?

Could they change the TRIGGERS? How?

Could they change the RESULTS? How?

Any other ideas?